

doc-spirit-filioque

Open / Uncertain · Pneumatology › Person · doctrine · divided_lineages · confidence: medium

Statement under examination

The Holy Spirit also eternally proceeds from the Son (filioque, per the Western tradition).

Rationale

Scripture supplies one direct procession text. John 15:26 names the Father as the source from whom the Spirit *ekporeuetai* (G1607, present indicative of continuous proceeding) *para tou patros* (G3844 G3962, from the Father). The Son's role in the verse is the temporal sending: *ego pempso* (G3992, future indicative, I will send) *hymin para tou patros* (G3844). Two distinct verbs are deployed and they are not interchanged. The verb *ekporeuomai* is reserved for the Father as source; *pempo* and *exapostello* (G1821, Gal 4:6) are reserved for the temporal sending in salvation history. The Western argument (the Son also sends the Spirit and the Spirit is called the Spirit of the Son Rom 8:9, Gal 4:6, so an eternal procession through or from the Son is implied) reads ontological procession out of economic sending. The Eastern counter (the temporal sending is real and lexically clear, but it is not the same word the Bible uses for eternal procession, and reading one into the other is inference, not lexical demonstration) is honest. Scripture says the Father is the source, names the Son as a participant in sending and in possessing the Spirit, and stops there. The question of eternal hypostatic procession from or through the Son is not directly settled by the canonical lexical pattern. Verdict honestly contested.

Reasoning

The question is whether the Holy Spirit eternally proceeds from the Son as well as from the Father, or only from the Father. The Bible has one verse that directly names the Spirit's procession. John 15:26 says the Spirit proceeds from the Father. Jesus also says in the same verse that he will send the Spirit, but the word for proceeding and the word for sending are two different Greek words, and the Bible never swaps them. The strongest reason for the Western position is that the Son does in fact send the Spirit. John 16:7 says Jesus will send the Helper. John 20:22 shows Jesus breathing the Spirit onto the disciples. Galatians 4:6 says God sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts. Romans 8:9 calls the Spirit the Spirit of Christ. The Western argument is that this temporal sending in time reflects an eternal procession before time, because what God does in time matches who God is in eternity. The strongest counterargument is that the Bible itself does not take that final step. The Bible says the Father is the source of procession and that the Son sends the Spirit in salvation history. It does not directly say the Son is also a source of eternal procession. Reading the temporal sending back into eternity is a careful theological inference, not a direct biblical statement. Another complicating factor is John 15:26 itself. Jesus had the perfect moment to say from the Father and from me but he did not. He said from the Father. The verdict here is honestly contested. The Bible supplies one direct procession text and it names only the Father. The Bible supplies many sending texts that include the Son. Whether sending in time implies procession in eternity is a theological judgment that careful Christians have answered differently for over a thousand years. The verdict cannot be settled from the canonical lexical evidence alone without taking sides on a debate Scripture does not directly resolve. Both sides confess the full deity of the Spirit and the equality of the Son and the Father.

Denominational landscape

This question is the central theological flashpoint of the 1054 split between the Western Latin church and the Eastern Greek church, and it remains unresolved more than nine hundred years later. The Western position that the Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son is held by the Roman Catholic Church, by

Lutheran churches in the Book of Concord, by Anglican churches in Article 5 of the Thirty-Nine Articles, by Reformed churches in the major confessions, by Methodist churches in Article 4 of the Articles of Religion, and by most Pentecostal, Anabaptist, and evangelical Protestant bodies. The Methodist Articles say plainly that the Holy Ghost proceeds from the Father and the Son. The clause was first added to the Nicene Creed at the Third Council of Toledo in Spain in the year 589 and gradually spread through the Western church. The Eastern Orthodox churches reject the clause on two grounds. First, they hold that it was added by the Western church without the authority of an ecumenical council, which makes the addition procedurally invalid. Second, they hold that it disturbs what they call the monarchy of the Father, the teaching that within the Trinity the Father alone is the source of the other two Persons. Carriers of the rejection include the Greek Orthodox Church, the Russian Orthodox Church, the Antiochian Orthodox Church, the Orthodox Church in America, and the Oriental Orthodox churches. Both sides fully affirm the deity of the Spirit and the equality of the three Persons. This is not a deity-of-the-Spirit dispute and it is not a salvation-issue dispute. Public-record cult or clearly heterodox movements such as Jehovah's Witnesses, Mormonism, Christadelphians, and Iglesia ni Cristo do not meaningfully participate in this debate because they reject the deity or personhood of the Spirit at a more basic level, well before they reach the question of procession. The honest verdict for a tradition-neutral lexical baseline is contested. A reader can hold either the Western or the Eastern position in good faith and remain within historic Christianity.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	Yes
Would be member if otherwise	Yes
Would let children be taught otherwise	Yes
Would marry if held otherwise	Yes
Would publicly correct if otherwise	No

Notes

This is the central theological flashpoint of the 1054 Great Schism between Rome and Constantinople and the longest-running unresolved in-house Christian disagreement. The question stem as written pre-loads the Western verdict. Working the neutralized form: does the Spirit proceed eternally from the Son also, or only from the Father with the Son as the agent through whom temporal mission sending occurs. The canonical lexical pattern supports the temporal sending by the Son unambiguously (John 16:7 pempso, John 20:22 enephyesen and Labete pneuma hagon, Gal 4:6 exapesteilen, Rom 8:9 Pneuma Christou). It does NOT lexically demonstrate eternal procession from the Son. The Western (Latin) tradition built a logically coherent inference from temporal sending to eternal procession; the Eastern (Greek) tradition holds that this inference both exceeds Scripture and disturbs the monarchy of the Father (the Father alone as fontal source within the Godhead). Both sides confess the full deity of the Spirit, the consubstantiality of the Persons, and the equality of the Son with the Father. The Filioque debate is internal to orthodox Trinitarianism, not a deity-of-Spirit question. Carriers of the affirmative position: Catholic Church, Lutheran Book of Concord, Anglican 39 Articles Article V, Reformed confessions, Methodist Articles of Religion Article IV, most Pentecostal and Anabaptist bodies. Carriers of denial: Eastern Orthodox communions

(Greek, Russian, Antiochian, OCA, Coptic to a related but distinct degree), Oriental Orthodox, Assyrian Church of the East. Public-record cult or heterodox carriers do NOT meaningfully participate in this debate because they generally deny or distort the deity or personhood of the Spirit prior to reaching this question. The cult-marker bar is firmly NOT met. Eastern Orthodox Christians who deny the Filioque are not denying the gospel or the Spirit's deity; they are denying a Latin theological inference and a procedurally added creedal clause. The honest verdict given the user's tradition-neutral lexical baseline is contested. The user is Plymouth Brethren-adjacent; the Brethren tradition inherits the Western position by default but the question has not historically been a Brethren distinctive or a Brethren disciplinary line. The reader can adopt either Western or Eastern verdict in good faith from this baseline; both lineages have careful canonical exegetes.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. Does the Holy Spirit proceed eternally from the Son also, or does eternal procession terminate at the Father with the Son's role being the temporal mission sending in salvation history?

Notes. The stem asserts the Western verdict (the Spirit also eternally proceeds from the Son) and parenthetically labels it as the Western tradition. This is the doctrine on trial in the East-West dispute, not a neutral proposition. The neutralized form preserves the lexical question without taking the Latin inference as given. Flag stem-pre-loaded-verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. western-latin-trinitarian, eastern-greek-trinitarian

analogia scripturae invoked

Competing lens verdicts

western-latin-trinitarian · **affirms:**

eastern-greek-trinitarian · **denies:**

Both lenses operate within orthodox Trinitarianism and confess the full deity of the Spirit. The dispute is between a careful inference from economic to immanent Trinity (West) and a careful refusal to read sending texts as procession texts (East). Grammatico-historical reading alone does not settle the question because the question is one of legitimate theological inference beyond direct lexical statement. Analogia scripturae is invoked on both sides; both can cite the same canonical texts and reach different conclusions. The user is Plymouth Brethren-adjacent, inheriting the Western position by default; the question has not been a Brethren disciplinary line. Honest baseline: contested between two legitimate Christian lenses on a question Scripture does not directly resolve at the lexical level.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

John.15.26 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key term. ἐκπορεύεται *ekporeuetai* G1607 (proceeds, present indicative of continuous proceeding); παρὰ τοῦ πατρὸς *para tou patros* G3844 G3962 (from the Father); πέμψω *pempso* G3992 (I will send, future indicative active); τὸ πνεῦμα τῆς ἀληθείας *to pneuma tes aletheias* G4151 G225 (the Spirit of truth)

Force. The only direct procession verse in the canon. Two verbs are deployed and they are NOT swapped. The Father is named as the source of the Spirit's procession (*ekporeuomai*). The Son is named as the future temporal sender (*pempo*). The preposition *para* with the genitive marks the Father as the personal source from whose side the Spirit comes. The Son says I will send from the Father, NOT from me and from the Father. Lexically this verse undergirds only the procession from the Father; it neither affirms nor denies a parallel procession from the Son.

John.16.7 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. πέμψω αὐτὸν πρὸς ὑμᾶς *pempso auton pros hymas* G3992 (I will send him to you); παράκλητος *parakletos* G3875 (Helper, Advocate)

Force. The Son names himself as the sender of the Spirit in salvation history. The verb is *pempo*, future indicative active. This is a temporal mission-sending text, not a procession text. The Western argument moves from this temporal sending to an eternal procession through or from the Son. The Eastern counter holds the lexical distinction firm: temporal sending is real but does not entail eternal procession.

John.20.22 · for · genre: gospel · figures: typology

Key term. ἐνεφύσησεν *enephyseisen* G1720 (he breathed on, aorist indicative active); Λάβετε πνεῦμα ἅγιον *Labete pneuma hagion* G2983 G4151 G40 (Receive the Holy Spirit, aorist imperative)

Force. Post-resurrection commissioning. The Son breathes the Spirit onto the disciples and commands them to receive. The verb *enephyseisen* echoes the Septuagint of Gen 2:7 (God breathing the breath of life into Adam) and Ezek 37:9 (breath into the dry bones). Western theology reads this gesture as economic enactment of an eternal relation; Eastern theology reads it as a Christ-mediated reception of the Father's gift. The text supports the Son's role in giving the Spirit; it does not directly demonstrate eternal procession.

Rom.8.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. πνεῦμα θεοῦ *pneuma theou* G4151 G2316 (Spirit of God); πνεῦμα Χριστοῦ *pneuma Christou* G4151 G5547 (Spirit of Christ)

Force. Paul uses Spirit of God and Spirit of Christ as functionally interchangeable. Possession of the Spirit and belonging to Christ are coordinate. Western theology cites this lexical equivalence as evidence that the Spirit is intrinsically related to the Son, supporting procession from or through the Son. Eastern theology accepts the lexical equivalence but reads it as relational and economic rather than fontal: the Spirit belongs to and rests upon the Son without proceeding hypostatically from him.

Gal.4.6 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐξαπέστειλεν ὁ θεὸς τὸ πνεῦμα τοῦ υἱοῦ αὐτοῦ *exapesteilen ho theos to pneuma tou huiou autou* G1821 G2316 G4151 G5207 (God sent forth the Spirit of his Son); κρᾶζον Ἀββὰ ὁ πατήρ *krazon Abba ho pater* G2896 G5 G3962 (crying Abba Father)

Force. The Father is the explicit grammatical agent of the sending: God sent forth (*exapesteilen*, aorist indicative active). The Spirit is identified as the Spirit of the Son. The Son is not the sender in this verse; God the Father is. The Spirit's witness in believers cries Abba Father, directing relation back to the Father. The text complicates a simple from-the-Son procession reading by placing the agency of sending with the Father even when the Spirit is named in relation to the Son.

Acts.2.33 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key term. τῇ δεξιᾷ τοῦ θεοῦ ὑψωθείς te dexia tou theou hypsotheis G1188 G2316 G5312 (exalted at the right hand of God); τὴν ἐπαγγελίαν τοῦ πνεύματος τοῦ ἁγίου λαβὼν παρὰ τοῦ πατρὸς ten epangelian tou pneumatos tou hagiou labon para tou patros G1860 G4151 G40 G2983 G3844 G3962 (having received the promise of the Holy Spirit from the Father); ἐξέχεεν exeichen G1632 (he poured out)

Force. Peter's Pentecost sermon names a precise sequence: the exalted Son receives the promised Spirit from the Father (para tou patros) and then pours him out on the church. The Son's role is mediation of the Father's gift: he receives, then pours. The lexical pattern para tou patros mirrors John 15:26 exactly. The Son distributes; the Father is the fontal source. This is a key complicating text for the Western argument.

John.14.16 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key term. ἐγὼ ἐρωτήσω τὸν πατέρα ego eroteso ton patera G2065 G3962 (I will ask the Father); ἄλλον παράκλητον δώσει allos parakleton dosei G243 G3875 G1325 (he will give another Helper)

Force. Procession-adjacent text. The Son says he will ask the Father, and the Father will give the Spirit. The agency is again the Father's, with the Son interceding. The Western argument reads the Son's role as decisive and joint with the Father; the Eastern argument reads the Son as the mediating asker while the Father remains the giver and source. The lexical pattern in this verse aligns with John 15:26 and Acts 2:33.

John.14.26 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key term. τὸ πνεῦμα τὸ ἅγιον ὃ πέμψει ὁ πατήρ ἐν τῷ ὀνόματί μου to pneuma to hagion ho pempsei ho pater en to onomati mou G4151 G40 G3992 G3962 G3686 (the Holy Spirit whom the Father will send in my name)

Force. The Father is the sender; the sending is in the name of the Son. This text places the Father as the agent of mission-sending and the Son as the one whose name authorizes and identifies the mission. It complements John 15:26 and provides additional texture: even in temporal sending, the Father is sometimes named as agent and the Son as the one in whose name the Spirit comes. The Eastern argument cites this verse as further evidence that the Son's role in the Spirit's mission is mediating and naming, not originating.

Phil.1.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. ἐπιχορηγίας τοῦ πνεύματος Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ epichoregias tou pneumatos Iesou Christou G2024 G4151 G2424 G5547 (the supply of the Spirit of Jesus Christ)

Force. Paul names the Spirit as the Spirit of Jesus Christ. The genitive can be possessive (the Spirit belonging to Jesus), source (the Spirit from Jesus), or characterizing (the Spirit who bears Christ's character). The Western argument prefers the source reading and links it back to eternal procession. The Eastern argument prefers the possessive and characterizing readings and treats source language as economic, not ontological.

1Pet.1.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. πνεῦμα Χριστοῦ pneuma Christou G4151 G5547 (Spirit of Christ); προμαρτυρόμενον promartyromenon G4303 (testifying beforehand)

Force. Peter names the Spirit who was in the Old Testament prophets the Spirit of Christ. This is striking because it places the Spirit of Christ in active witness before the incarnation. Western theology cites this as evidence that the Spirit eternally bears a relation to the Son. Eastern theology agrees on the relation but reads it as the Spirit's eternal resting upon the Son (the Father's anointing) rather than the Spirit's procession from the Son.

Rev.22.1 · complicates · genre: apocalyptic · figures: apocalyptic-symbolism, metaphor

Key term. ποταμὸν ὕδατος ζωῆς potamon hydatos zoes G4215 G5204 G2222 (a river of the water of life); ἐκπορευόμενον ἐκ τοῦ θρόνου τοῦ θεοῦ καὶ τοῦ ἀρνίου ekporeuomenon ek tou thronou tou theou kai tou arniou G1607 G2362 G2316 G721 (proceeding from the throne of God and of the Lamb)

Force. This is the only other use of the verb ekporeuomai in a procession-adjacent sense in connection with God and the Lamb. The river of the water of life proceeds from the throne of God AND of the Lamb. Some Western theologians cite this verse as a typological echo supporting the Spirit's procession from both Persons. The Eastern counter is that the imagery is the throne (a single shared throne for God and the Lamb) and the river is the Spirit's gift in the eschatological city, not a statement of eternal hypostatic procession. The text is apocalyptic-symbolic; it does not bear the weight of direct dogmatic settlement.

Luke.24.49 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key term. ἀποστέλλω τὴν ἐπαγγελίαν τοῦ πατρὸς μου ἐφ' ὑμᾶς apostello ten epangelian tou patros mou eph hymas G649 G1860 G3962 (I send the promise of my Father upon you)

Force. The Son sends the promise of the Father. The verb is apostello, not ekporeuomai. The grammatical structure preserves the same pattern: the Father is the source of the promise; the Son distributes it. The mission texts consistently use sending verbs (pempo, apostello, exapostello) and never the procession verb (ekporeuomai). This lexical distinction is the strongest point in the Eastern argument.

John.7.39 · for · genre: gospel

Key term. οὐπω γὰρ ἦν πνεῦμα οὐρο gar en pneuma G3768 G4151 (for the Spirit was not yet); δοξασθῆναι doxasthenai G1392 (to be glorified)

Force. Narrative footnote: the Spirit was not yet given because Jesus was not yet glorified. This is an economic-sequence text. The Spirit's coming in the new-covenant fullness is conditional on the Son's glorification. Western theology reads this as ontological grounding of procession through the Son; Eastern theology reads it as economic ordering of mission, not ontological procession.

Concordance lemmas traversed

G1607, G3992, G649, G1821, G3844, G3962, G4151, G225, G40, G5547, G2316, G5207, G3875, G1720, G2983, G1325, G2065, G243, G3686, G1860, G1632, G2024, G2424, G4303, G4215, G5204, G2222, G2362, G721, G3768, G1392, G2896, G5, G1188, G5312

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Augustine, On the Trinity (De Trinitate) Book XV, NPNF1 Vol 3, ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf103 · affirms · unverified

“The Holy Spirit proceeds principally from the Father, and yet also from the Son, as from a common principle, by the gift of the Father to the Son.”

patristic · Photius of Constantinople, Mystagogy of the Holy Spirit (9th c.) · denies · unverified

“The Father alone is the cause and source of the divinity. To insert another origin into the Trinity is to introduce two principles and to overturn the monarchy of the Father.”

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraphs 246-248, vatican.va · affirms · unverified

“The Latin tradition of the Creed confesses that the Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son (Filioque). The Holy Spirit's eternal origin is at the deep mystery of the divine life. The Father is the first origin, but the Son is also true source of the Spirit's eternal procession.”

lutheran · Athanasian Creed received in Book of Concord, bookofconcord.org · affirms · unverified

“The Holy Ghost is of the Father and of the Son; neither made, nor created, nor begotten, but proceeding.”

anglican · Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion (1571), Article V Of the Holy Ghost, churchofengland.org · affirms · unverified

“The Holy Ghost, proceeding from the Father and the Son, is of one substance, majesty, and glory, with the Father and the Son, very and eternal God.”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith Chapter 2 Section 3 On the Holy Trinity · affirms · unverified

“The Holy Ghost eternally proceeding from the Father and the Son.”

methodist · Methodist Articles of Religion Article IV Of the Holy Ghost, umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion · affirms · verified

“The Holy Ghost, proceeding from the Father and the Son, is of one substance, majesty, and glory with the Father and the Son, very and eternal God.”

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession of Faith (1632), Article I On God and the Creation of All Things · affirms · unverified

“We believe in the one eternal almighty God, the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, three Persons in one divine being, generally following the Western Trinitarian creed.”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths Article 2 The One True God, ag.org/Beliefs/Statement-of-Fundamental-Truths · affirms · unverified

“The one true God has revealed Himself as the eternally self-existent Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, the Holy Spirit proceeding from the Father and the Son according to historic Christian creeds.”

eastern_orthodox · Orthodox Church in America teaching on the Symbol of Faith, oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine-scripture · denies · unverified

“The Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father alone. The Latin addition of Filioque to the Creed is both procedurally illegitimate and theologically erroneous; it confuses the Spirit's eternal procession with his temporal mission through the Son.”

Web sources

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/john/15-26.htm>

“John 15:26 ekporeuetai (G1607) para tou patros (G3844 G3962); pempso (G3992) future indicative. Two distinct verbs, never swapped.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/john/16-7.htm>

“John 16:7 pempso auton pros hymas (G3992 V-FIA-1S, I will send him to you). Temporal mission-sending verb, not the procession verb.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/john/20-22.htm>

“John 20:22 enephyseisen (G1720) aorist; Labete pneuma hagion (G2983 G4151 G40) aorist imperative. Christ breathes the Spirit onto the disciples.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/romans/8-9.htm>

“Rom 8:9 pneuma theou and pneuma Christou (G4151 G5547) used in parallel. Spirit of God and Spirit of Christ name the same Person.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/galatians/4-6.htm>

“Gal 4:6 exapesteilen ho theos (G1821 G2316) aorist indicative active. God the Father is the grammatical agent of sending the Spirit of his Son.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongsgreek/1607.htm>

“G1607 ekporeuomai: to proceed, depart, come forth. 34 NT occurrences. Procession-related use in John 15:26 and Rev 22:1 (river from throne of God and Lamb).”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“Methodist Article IV: The Holy Ghost, proceeding from the Father and the Son, is of one substance, majesty, and glory with the Father and the Son, very and eternal God.”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict
- confession-tradition-divergence
- irreducible-east-west-divide
- apparatus-vs-counter-witness-conflict
- apparatus-paywalled